

cover story NAXALITES

vatising the response to the militancy and shrugging off the state's responsibility. Salwa Judum separates and arms anti-Naxalite villagers, making them easy to identify and attack, not to mention drying up the flow of intelligence from Maoist-controlled villages. Predictably, this effort is bound to fail.

Lack of coordination and sharing of intelligence inputs has helped them expand their areas of influence from one state to the other. The Maoists have traditionally exploited the porous Indo-Nepal border. Areas like West Champaran's Bagaha district along this border are emerging as prime recruitment grounds for them. They usually recruit poor tribals as their foot soldiers. The topography makes it possible to set up armed camps and conduct guerrilla warfare.

AMBUSHED: The Home Ministry is mulling over the need to increase the number of CRPF and BSF battalions

pose, the utilisation of which has been abysmal. The same holds true for Bihar too, which is yet to fully utilise its share.

If the counter-insurgency strategy has been somewhat effective in Andhra Pradesh, it is largely because of the exclusive intelligence gathering mechanism, police's informant networks, the prompt dispatch of the elite commando force called Greyhounds to the forest areas where the militants go into hiding and, above all, minimal political intervention. Still, the seizure of huge quantity of ammunition and explosives suggests the militants are arming themselves. That they have strong contacts with LTTE, begun operations from a new base in Darjeeling and joined hands with ULFA in Assam suggests they are working on plans to scale up the conflict.

All affected states have now begun beefing up security. The Naxalites are now more professional than ever before,



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THE HEAVY TOLL

YEAR	INCIDENTS	POLICE personnel killed	CIVILIANS killed	MAOISTS killed
2003	1,597	105	410	216
2004	1,533	100	466	87
2005	1,608	153	524	225
2006	1,509	157	521	272
2007 (half)	842	138	220	93

THE STATE RESPONSE

■ Scheduled Tribes and other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act 2006, will go a long way in addressing widespread disaffection among people in the Naxal-affected areas.

■ **Rs 1,680 crore** has been provided to the Naxal-affected states under the backward district component of the Rashtriya Sam Vikas Yojana.

Source: The Union Home Ministry

Undoubtedly, intelligence gathering and information sharing are necessary for a counter strategy for which the Home Ministry has suggested sprucing of police level mechanism. Last year, it asked the state governments to accord top priority to strengthen the Special Branch of the police and set up inter-state intelligence support teams to spruce up intelligence gathering machinery at the district level or follow the practice of Andhra Pradesh which has set up an exclusive intelligence wing devoted to IWE. The state governments, however, are still to act on it.

Not only this. Most Maoist-affected states have some of the lowest police-to-population ratios. Funds allocated for police modernisation and expansion have either not been spent or invested on other things. Jharkhand, for instance, was provided Rs 1,82,700 crore over six years for this pur-

with squads patterned on army platoons, highly trained and motivated to execute attacks flawlessly. The Home Ministry is, therefore, examining CRPF's proposal for raising 118 battalions and Border Security Force's (BSF) suggestion to have an additional 39 battalions over the next 10 years. Currently, CRPF has 201 operational battalions while BSF has 157.

"What we are locked in is irregular warfare. We have to adapt if we are to overcome the odds we are up against," says Mahendra Lal Kumawat, special secretary (internal security). The states will have to create a better equipped police force even as they address the social issues raised by the Maoists. More than that, the state has to show political will to contain the barbarism of the countryside.

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